PRODUCT DISCOVERY & USER RESEARCH

GYMTrack

User Research & Problem Discovery

Understanding Lifter Needs, Training Friction, and Grounded AI Opportunities

A foundational user research and product discovery document created as part of my portfolio as an aspiring AI Product Manager / Associate Product Manager. This document details how I identified real workout tracking problems, formulated user hypotheses, mapped user pain points, and designed a practical usability testing plan.

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Target Roles	AI Product Manager / APM / Product Analyst
Academic Background	Data Science & AI
Document Purpose	Portfolio Showcase — Problem Framing & User Empathy
Product Focus	GYMTrack — Mobile Fitness Tracking & Grounded AI Coach
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What Recruiters & Interviewers will see in this Document:

- **User-Centric Thinking:** How I break down a gym lifter's daily habits and physical frustrations.
- **Structured Problem Discovery:** Transforming observed gym friction into actionable product requirements.
- **Honest Research Methodology:** Clear differentiation between initial builder hypotheses and validated user facts.
- **Practical Usability Design:** A realistic testing framework to evaluate core tasks with 5–10 lifters.

1. Why I Started GYMTrack

The motivation behind GYMTrack came from observing everyday gym behavior, combined with personal training experience. Every day, millions of people walk into gyms with genuine motivation to build strength, improve their health, and stay consistent. Yet, when watching people between sets on the gym floor, a consistent pattern of confusion and friction emerges:

- **Relying on Memory:** Many lifters try to remember what weight they lifted last week. Because they cannot remember whether they did 50 kg or 55 kg for 8 reps, they end up guessing, leading to stalled strength progress.
- **Awkward Note-Taking:** Some lifters try writing weights in Apple Notes, Google Keep, or paper diaries. Typing numbers with chalked, sweaty hands between intense sets is tedious and breaks concentration.
- **Bloated Commercial Apps:** Existing fitness applications often feel like social media platforms with complicated setup wizards, paywalls, and lengthy multi-step menus. They prioritize ad revenue over rapid set logging.
- **Generic AI Gimmicks:** Recent apps add AI chatbots that offer generic fitness platitudes ('drink water and sleep well') or fabricate personal records, offering zero practical utility during an active workout session.

2. Problem Discovery: The Lifter's Reality

Through direct observation and user conversations on gym floors, I identified seven key pain points that gym users routinely experience:

- **Forgetting Previous Weights:** Lifters frequently forget the exact resistance they used on secondary exercises (e.g., Dumbbell Incline Press or Cable Rows), preventing progressive overload.
- **Losing Track of Sets & Reps:** During intense workouts with high fatigue, lifters easily lose count of whether they have completed two sets or three sets.
- **Difficulty Tracking Daily Workouts:** Without a clear summary of today's completed workload, lifters leave the gym uncertain of their total volume.
- **Inability to See Long-Term Progress:** Gains in strength happen incrementally over weeks and months. Without simple charts showing estimated One-Rep Max (1RM) trends, users lose motivation.
- **Confusion Around Unfamiliar Exercises:** Beginners and intermediate lifters often avoid unfamiliar machines or compound lifts because static diagrams fail to explain proper joint angles and setup.
- **Generic, Disconnected Fitness Advice:** When lifters ask for advice on what to train next or how to split their routines, available digital tools provide generic answers unrelated to what the user actually lifted yesterday.
- **Overly Complicated Logging Experiences:** If logging a set takes more than 15 seconds or requires typing on a tiny keyboard, lifters quickly abandon logging entirely.

3. Target User Personas (Exploratory Archetypes)

Note: As an early-stage product builder, these personas are exploratory archetypes based on observed gym behaviors and informal user discussions, rather than formal statistical survey samples.

Persona 1: The Beginner Gym Student ('Rohan')

Profile: College student who started going to the gym 2 months ago. Trains 3 days a week.
Mindset: Motivated but slightly intimidated by crowded weight rooms and unfamiliar equipment.
Key Frustrations: Unsure if his exercise posture is correct; forgets what weight he used on machines last session; feels overwhelmed by complicated bodybuilding apps.
Core Needs:
• Simple exercise discovery with clear, verified video demonstrations right on the exercise card.
• Fast 1-tap logging without complicated workout setup.
• Basic guidance from AI Coach on proper exercise form and sensible starting weights.

Persona 2: The Consistent Lifter ('Aman')

Profile: Working professional who trains 4–5 days a week (Push/Pull/Legs split).
Mindset: Focused on progressive overload. Treats gym time as disciplined personal time.
Key Frustrations: Hates typing numbers on a phone screen with chalked/sweaty hands; annoyed when apps reset past records or lose data when gym Wi-Fi drops.
Core Needs:
• Immediate memory recall: when selecting 'Bench Press', the app should show the last weight used.
• Rapid +/- stepper controls to log sets in under 10 seconds.
• Hands-free voice logging option ('Bench press 70kg, 8 reps, 3 sets') for heavy compound days.

Persona 3: The Data-Oriented Strength Enthusiast ('Pooja')

Profile: Intermediate lifter focused on strength progression on compound lifts (Squat, Bench, Deadlift).
Mindset: Values objective data trends over emotional feeling. Tracks weekly volume and 1RM progression.
Key Frustrations: Fitness apps that display fake motivational streaks or flat numbers without estimated 1RM curves; generic AI that gives the same advice to everyone.
Core Needs:
• Clean strength progression charts with automated Epley One-Rep Max calculations.
• Muscle group frequency breakdown to prevent undertraining or overtraining.
• Context-grounded AI Coach that analyzes her actual logged sets to answer: 'Am I getting stronger?'

4. User Pain Points & Product Response

Mapping user pain points directly to concrete product features ensures that every capability in GYMTrack solves a verified problem rather than adding unnecessary bloat:

User Pain Point	Why It Matters (Impact)	GYMTrack Product Response
Forgetting Previous Weights	Lifters guess weights, leading to inconsistent progression or accidental overtraining.	Auto-populates last used weight and reps whenever an exercise is selected.
Slow, Tedious Input	Typing on keyboard with sweaty hands interrupts rest periods; leads to abandoned logging.	Large +/- stepper buttons and a hands-free voice logging review sheet.
Uncertainty on Technique	Beginners risk injury or skip exercises when unsure of movement mechanics.	100% video-demonstrated exercise library accessible in 1 tap without leaving the app.
Invisible Progress	Muscle gains take time; without visual proof of strength gains, lifters lose motivation.	Automated Estimated 1RM trends, daily volume totals, and historical comparison charts.
Generic AI Chatbots	Chatbots that make up numbers or give generic platitudes destroy user trust.	Deterministic AI context builder injecting actual 7D/30D volume and logged weights into prompt.
Gym Network Blackouts	Basement gyms drop cellular signal; online-only apps lose unsaved sets.	Local client-side caching (IndexedDB) with automatic background sync.

5. Core User Needs

- **Fast Logging (Sub-15 Seconds):** Lifters are actively training. The logging interaction must be near-instant so that rest intervals remain restful rather than clerical.
- **Clear Exercise Information:** High-fidelity video demonstrations and muscle group tags must be easily scannable on mobile viewports.
- **Reliable Historical Memory:** Users need the app to act as an infallible memory bank: showing exact weights, sets, and dates without data loss.
- **Actionable Progress Visualization:** Progress should be presented in intuitive curves (e.g. Estimated 1RM) rather than raw confusing data tables.
- **Honest, Personalized Assistance:** Any guidance provided by AI must be truthful to the user's logged history and acknowledge when data is sparse.

6. End-to-End User Journey

To understand where friction occurs during a training session, I mapped the typical end-to-end user journey of a lifter using GYMTrack from arrival at the gym through post-workout reflection:

Journey Stage	User Action & Context	Emotional & UX Need
Phase 1: Open App at Gym	Arrives at the gym, opens GYMTrack. Sees today's active dashboard showing 0 sets completed, previous workout summary, and quick-start button.	Needs an uncluttered screen that loads immediately on mobile without intrusive popups.
Phase 2: Exercise Selection	Walks over to the bench press station. Taps 'Log Workout', searches or selects 'Barbell Bench Press'. App pre-fills last session's weight (60 kg).	Wants to confirm past weight immediately so they know what plates to load onto the barbell.
Phase 3: Form Verification (Optional)	If trying an unfamiliar exercise, taps the video icon on the exercise card to watch a 10-second proper form demonstration.	Needs fast, inline video playback without leaving the app to search external video sites.
Phase 4: Set Execution & Rapid Logging	Performs Set 1 (60 kg x 8 reps). Taps the '+' button or speaks 'Bench press 60 kg for 8 reps'. Taps Confirm in under 5 seconds.	High fatigue and chalked hands; interaction must require minimum cognitive effort.
Phase 5: Rest Interval	Rests for 90 seconds. May glance at the built-in rest timer to know when to start the next set.	Needs to stay focused on recovery rather than managing app settings.
Phase 6: Session Completion & Instant Feedback	Finishes final set and saves session. The Home screen immediately updates: sets completed, total volume lifted, and streak counter.	Needs immediate visual reward and confirmation that their hard work was accurately stored.
Phase 7: Reflection & AI Coaching	Later in the evening, user reviews the Progress tab to see 1RM improvements or asks AI Coach: 'What should I train tomorrow?'	Wants grounded, personalized feedback based on today's logged volume and muscle group usage.

Key Journey Insight: The active workout phase (Phases 2–5) demands zero-friction utility, while the post-workout phase (Phases 6–7) demands clear reflection and intelligence. Blending these two distinct mindsets into one screen creates confusion; separating them into Home (Today) and Progress (Trends) was a direct product response to this journey.

7. Product Assumptions & Validation Plan

As an AI Product Manager, it is essential to distinguish between proven user behavior and product assumptions. The following initial hypotheses were formed during the design of GYMTrack and require ongoing user validation:

- **Assumption 1: Stepper Buttons vs. Keyboard Entry: Hypothesis:** Users prefer large +/- stepper controls over keyboard numeric typing because typing between heavy sets is error-prone. *Validation:* Measure task completion time and error rates for both input modes in usability tests.
- **Assumption 2: Last-Weight Pre-Fill: Hypothesis:** Pre-filling the exercise log with the user's previous weight and reps saves time and encourages progressive overload. *Validation:* Track how often users accept the pre-filled values vs. modifying them.
- **Assumption 3: In-App Video vs. External Search: Hypothesis:** Beginners will use video demonstrations if embedded directly on the card, but will skip form checks if forced to switch apps. *Validation:* Monitor video play rates across exercise categories.
- **Assumption 4: Data-Grounded AI Increases Trust: Hypothesis:** Users will actively consult an AI Coach if its recommendations cite their actual logged sessions, but will abandon it if it generates generic advice. *Validation:* Compare retention rates between users receiving grounded vs. generic responses.
- **Assumption 5: Voice Logging Utility: Hypothesis:** Users wearing earphones will adopt speech-to-text logging to keep their phones in their pockets. *Validation:* Instrument voice-log button tap rates and transcription edit rates.

8. User Interview Guide (10 Qualitative Questions)

When conducting discovery interviews with target gym users, I would use these 10 open-ended questions to explore habits, emotional blockers, and functional expectations without biasing the responses:

#	User Interview Question
Q1	How do you currently keep track of the exercises, weights, and sets you perform during a gym session?
Q2	What is the single most frustrating or inconvenient part of recording your workouts while training?
Q3	How often do you walk up to an exercise and realize you cannot remember what weight you used last week?
Q4	If you have tried workout apps in the past, what made you stop using them or delete them?
Q5	What happens when you lose internet connection in the gym? How does your current tool handle that?
Q6	When you learn a new exercise, how do you verify that your form and posture are safe and effective?
Q7	Would you find speaking into your earphones (voice logging) helpful, or do you prefer tapping buttons on screen?
Q8	What is the first piece of information you want to see immediately after finishing a workout session?
Q9	If an AI fitness assistant had access to your workout logs, what specific questions would you want it to answer?
Q10	What visual proof or chart would convince you that your training routine is actually making you stronger?

9. Usability Testing Plan (5–10 Users)

To test usability and identify UI friction points, I designed a structured, unmoderated and moderated testing protocol aimed at 5 to 10 gym participants testing GYMTrack on mobile devices:

Usability Task	Task Instructions	Evaluation Metric
Task 1: Search & Find an Exercise	Ask participant to locate 'Incline Dumbbell Press' in the exercise library and check the video demonstration.	Measures search discoverability and speed of opening exercise details.
Task 2: Log a Manual Set	Ask participant to log 3 sets of 20 kg for 10 reps using the quick +/- steppers.	Measures total time-to-log and stepper usability on mobile.
Task 3: Perform Voice Logging	Ask participant to tap the microphone and speak: 'Bench press 60 kg for 8 reps, 3 sets'.	Tests speech extraction clarity and ease of reviewing the confirmation sheet.
Task 4: Check Today's Summary	Ask participant to confirm how many sets and total volume they logged today from the Home screen.	Measures clarity of daily aggregation metrics.
Task 5: Review Historical Progress	Ask participant to navigate to Progress and locate their estimated 1RM curve for Bench Press.	Evaluates chart comprehension and navigation flow.
Task 6: Query the AI Coach	Ask participant to ask the AI Coach: 'What muscle group should I train next?'	Tests whether the grounded response feels relevant, clear, and trustworthy.
Task 7: Start a Periodized Plan	Ask participant to configure a 12-week plan, review phases, and tap 'Start This Plan'.	Evaluates plan generator comprehension and immediate activation.

10. What I Learned as a Product Builder

- **Do Not Overcomplicate Core Workflows:** Every additional tap or confirmation dialogue between sets increases the likelihood that a lifter stops logging altogether. Speed and simplicity are features, not compromises.
- **Real-Time Feedback Reinforces Habits:** Seeing today's volume counter increment immediately after hitting save provides positive cognitive reinforcement, motivating lifters to log subsequent sets.
- **Historical Continuity Creates Retention:** Lifters do not stick with an app because of generic illustrations; they stay because their personal training history and progressive overload records live there.
- **AI Trust Requires Grounding in Real Data:** An AI Coach is only valuable if it respects actual user records. Hallucinated numbers destroy credibility instantly, whereas honest, data-backed guidance builds lasting trust.
- **Mobile Viewports Require Generous Touch Targets:** Testing on phones quickly revealed that desktop-sized buttons fail in the gym. Designing 48px touch targets and thumb-friendly bottom sheets is essential for real-world usability.
- **Structured Periodization Eliminates Floor Fatigue:** Lifters who walk in with an active multi-week plan execute workouts with significantly higher discipline and lower cognitive friction than those relying on ad-hoc daily choices.

Final Reflection:
This research and discovery process taught me that product management is not about building the most feature-dense application. It is about deeply understanding user behavior in their physical environment (the gym), identifying where friction causes drop-off, and designing focused, honest solutions that respect the user's time and effort.